



Then The Net Happened

Those of us born around 1980 are fortunate: we witnessed the prime time of tech in the prime of our youth

The WWW. Dial-up. Broadband. Netscape. The browser wars. Windows. Linux. The Pentium. The DVD. Napster. Google. PDAs. Cell phones. That about sums up the 1990s, except it doesn't describe how our PCs transitioned from a luxury item to a staple, and it sidelines AMD.

As we said earlier, Apple's products were niche offerings by 1990. During this decade, the company defined that niche better, coming up with innovative, colourful products—literally and figuratively. 1991 saw the Macintosh PowerBook series, Apple's first truly portable computers. They came with a 16-bit Motorola CPU, 2 MB of RAM, a hard disk ranging from 20 to 40 MB, and a 640 x 400 black and white screen. As an aside, 20 MB was quite the size for hard disks back then: 30 or 40 MB was considered large.

The fruity-coloured iMacs were launched only in 1998, with their hockey-puck mice. Specs: 233 MHz PowerPC 750, a 4 GB hard disk, and 32 MB of RAM. The monitor was translucent, and these machines ran dead quiet. Some say that even this addition of colour was imitated by the Wintel alliance, with cabinets now coming in black, silver, and grey! In 1999 came the equally colourful iBooks, as well as the PowerMac G4.

Yes, the '90s were good times for Mac lovers (already there was a cult of Mac lovers, or fans, or addicts, or advocates). "Think

different", they were told—and that's what they did. While Apple was being innovative in the features as well as the design departments, the company unfortunately, didn't revolutionise anything. The world was already sold on Windows—not so much sold on Windows 3.1 in 1992, but very, very much sold on Windows 95 in 1995. Reports at the time said people waited in long queues outside US stores August 24th, waiting to get the Windows 95 retail pack.

We can't sideline the importance of Windows 95: it wasn't merely an improvement over 3.x, it was the first "real" Windows. Crash-prone as hell, Apple fans might snigger, but for those of us who used it back then, it did the job. If you bought a new computer at the time, people would ask you if you'd managed to load Windows 95 on it—and lose interest in you if it turned out you were still using 3.x or even DOS. Windows 98, again, wasn't quite as revolutionary as the 95 version—it even had the same splash screen! But we all upgraded anyway, of course.

The operating systems were getting more demanding, but the hardware was keeping pace: March 22, 1993, the Intel Pentium microprocessor with its 3.1 million transistors saw the light, and (cutting a long story short) on May 7 1997 happened the Pentium II, with 7.5 million transistors. The low-cost

Celeron was out in 1998, and the Pentium III in '99. Our PCs might have been boring, with no trace of fruity colours, but the numbers I, II and III were important: they set the benchmarks for desktop processing power.

As for RAM, hard disks and such, well, so much happened then, we can't talk about it in this space! We'll just say that around 1995 onwards, components just kept getting faster and larger: the MHz/GHz/GB/whatever race had already begun. And since you're a *Digit* reader, you're well familiar with that. But for those who were too young to remember, we should mention that in 1995, a 1 GB hard disk was the envy of every kid on the block, and the corresponding figure for RAM was a whopping 32 MB! By 1999, these had become 30 or 40 GB and 256 MB respectively.

But what was a computer without the Internet to connect it to? All of a sudden—from a bird's-eye view of history, that is—this connection was as important as the computer. From the de-commissioning of ARPANET in 1990 to the WWW to broadband connections, all it took was one decade. The figures, while boring now, say it all. Here is the approximate number of hosts on the Internet by year:

1989: 1 lakh; 1990: 3 lakh; 1992: 10 lakh; 1996: 1 crore; 1998: 4 crore

Boring enough, but they're indicative of the growth of mankind's greatest creation! An

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